CONCLUSION | **RETURNS**

1989 and Beyond

In a divided culture, being undivided and synthesizing and connecting across broad areas can be an act of resistance. … And there's no firm dividing line between passionate political engagement and epiphany and pleasure. At the core of my writing is a desire to dissolve most of the cultural Berlin Walls running through our imaginations.
—REBECCA SOLNIT

Like the construction of the city's first border divisions in the early hours of August 13, 1961, the demise of the formidable Berlin Wall on November 9, 1989, similarly left citizens of East and West Berlin, and others around the world, in disbelief. The infamous Wall's fate, at both its onset and eventual undoing, quickly drew the attention and involvement of American cultural figures and others who identified with the events in Berlin as sites of division and transformation. *A Wall of Our Own* reads these two flashpoints of history for the ways they prompted a wide range of American artists, writers, and activists toward new critical explorations of the Berlin Wall and its legacies, tapping alternative circuits of cultural diplomacy to approach and pivot toward understandings of division in U.S. culture. Neither of these landmark dates signals a simple start or end of Cold War antagonisms in divided Berlin. Each, however, offers a vantage point to map, examine, engage, and push beyond the borderlands of Cold War Berlin. Cultural producers such as Leonard Freed, Angela Davis, Shinkichi Tajiri, Audre Lorde, and many others sought divided Berlin as site and symbol, to grapple with boundaries of freedom and repression. Without coordination or state sanction, they practiced a collective choreography of encountering the Wall, moving in and out of Berlin during the time of its militarized border, and relaying their perspectives in artworks and publications that touched on matters of U.S. identity, history, and struggle. From 1961 onward, their books, artworks, poems, and other artifacts illustrated both the ideals and the contradictions of U.S. Cold War culture. Through alternate circuits of cultural diplomacies, they engaged divided Berlin as a matter of critical pilgrimage, continually asking questions of themselves and of the Wall's